

CRMATTBURNETTGLADSTONEEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, and we are in the beautiful Gladstone region of Queensland. And I have the Mayor of the General Gladstone area, Matt Burnett, with me, Councillor Matt. Welcome, Matt, to the program.

Thanks for having me. Now, Matt, tell us about your background. You've been in the region for many, many years.

Well, you're born here, your family's been here. And tell us about your family background, first of all. Yeah, well, my family's been here for a long time.

I was born here, my mum was born here, my grandparents were born here, and my children and grandchildren, so six generations. Our family's been in the Gladstone region now. Yeah, so we love it here.

I've been on the council 25 years. Also represent Queensland as the state president of local government, and Australia as the national president of local government. So, local government is where it is for me.

I really love it. It's a bit of a cliché. Everyone says it's the closest to the people, but it is actually the facts.

And that's why I love so much about being on council. Now, your background, personally, you were a young lad, you were 19 years old, and you started your own local newspaper, which became successful in the region, and that's a fantastic start. Yeah, well, it was.

It was called the Port Curtis Post, and I was 19. Straight out of school, I did journalism at school, so I loved it. I started a university degree at Bachelor of Arts and Bachelor of Business, and I was working as the observer back in the day, when we still had print media everywhere, and decided I wanted to go out on my own, so I did my own thing.

For the first 12 months, it was just sport. I love sport, all sports. I would watch Australia play marbles, it was an option.

My advertisers, because it was a free newspaper, said they wanted us to go into more news, rather than just sport. So that's what we did. They focused on community news mostly, all positive news.

I like to make sure that we didn't focus on the negative, which would be nice if more media did something like that. I was reporting on council, and that's where I started. And it's not because I was really thinking, oh, I can do better.

I loved the process of watching how the decisions were made and how the process was

happening, and I thought, I want to be part of this. So it was a few decisions I wasn't happy with, either, but by and large, I thought the council was doing a good job, but I just wanted to be part of the team. Yeah, that's great.

And it gives you a really good in to the local community and all that sort of thing. And it's so important, isn't it, when you become onto local government or whatever, that you have a full background in the local community. There are some people that sort of parachuted in, and that's not really great.

No, you've got to have a love for the community. And you can tell how long my family's been here, how much I love the place for. You intend to stay here.

I'm not moving anywhere. Do you want to be part of the process, to make sure that Gladstone grew as a region and as a community and had facilities, services and infrastructure that my children and grandchildren would be able to take benefit of? And you have a look at our beautiful East Shores facilities now. I mean, I know for a fact that was my vote that helped make that happen.

We've got our cruise terminal. Auckland Hills has been redeveloped in the city. But as we amalgamated in 2008, part of the old Kalabi Shire, which includes Boyn Oll and Tenam Sands and the Boyne Valley, which is a very beautiful part of the world, and Mirringvale Shire, the old Mirringvale Shire, including Agnes Water, 1770, and deep water around those areas as well.

So Rules Beach, you know, it really is a beautiful part of the world. For those divers like me, from all over the world, you're right at the start of the Great Barrier Reef here, and you have Heron Island just off Gladstone. It must be tremendous having all those natural resources just on your doorstep.

Oh yes, the Southern Great Barrier Reef, the best part of the reef, I'm sorry, for anyone listening. It really is. It's really a spectacular part of the reef.

Diving on Heron Island, as you said, is amazing, but your Wilson Island right there as well. We've got Lady Musgrave Island, Lady Elliott Island as well, and Fitzroy Reef Lagoon is great for diving and snorkelling as well. So there's so much of this Capricorn Bunker Group, which includes to the north of us, Capel Island, which is realistically in the Livingston Shire.

Those other islands I mentioned earlier are all part of the Southern Great Barrier Reef. And in Agnes itself, it's because it's sort of the end of where the reef is, it's the northernmost surf beach as well. So the reef isn't breaking up the surf, so you can have surf there at Agnes, but you can be also at Lady Musgrave or Fitzroy Reef Lagoon in no time.

The thing is about this area too, it's a big stop-off point for the nomads, isn't it, when they're coming through, when they're doing from Brisbane up to Cairns. Yeah, it's obviously plenty of

places along the Bruce Highway, but particularly for us, we spend a lot of money renovating the park in Miriamvale, which is right on the Bruce Highway there. It's Elphalarson Park.

It pulls people into the little small town of Miriamvale, but renovating that park makes it very family friendly. And I know a lot of the great nomades might not necessarily have the younger generation with them. The coffee shops and the eateries in Miriamvale are boomed because of the redevelopment of the park there in the main street, and it's just a great place to pull up.

But of course, just up the road in Broran is a beautiful place to stop as well. Yeah, and I notice in town here, there's such a myriad of eateries, restaurants. I was at Ward's Brewery the other day with Michael Comley, who's the owner there, and it's such a great place where all these new things are springing up around Gladstone.

Yeah, well that's at the old Ward's Brewery, but it's the old Ward's Cordial Factory, and he's really encompassed the history of what the cordials that were made there and the soft drinks. And yeah, he's a local as well, so he wanted to make sure that the local history was preserved. And brews some of the best beers too, by the way, and won awards too.

So we've got two local breweries, Auckland House, which is down on East Shores, right on the waterfront there, beautiful part of the world. But he's in Auckland Street there at the Ward's Brewery, and yeah, as I said, he's won some awards for his amazing beers. Yes, I sampled one of his beers the other day, just one because I was responsible, but the beer that we sampled is up for gold medal at the Melbourne Beer Festival.

Beer awards, so it's fantastic. And what are some of the initiatives that you're looking at for the future of Gladstone for expansion? So for us, it's not just around tourism. Obviously, we're a very big industrial town, and so for us, the biggest issue is around decarbonisation of our major industries.

So we have Rio Tinto, has an alumina refinery, we have Aluminium Smelter in Point Island, Queensland Illumina Limited is another alumina refinery. We've got a cement facility at Cement Australia, Orica, which is chemicals. Alpha HPA, which is high purity alumina.

Fortescue, which is manufacturing electrolyzers and also will be producing hydrogen soon. And a lot of renewable energy projects in the pipeline, including one that's already right now, which is the Axiona project, which will deliver green energy to our market and will allow our major industries to purchase renewable energy and sell their product to the world using green power. So we have a massive state development area, which allows future development of major industry but also renewable projects.

It allows for our industrial ecosystem to grow. So by introducing hydrogen and other projects into it, one industry's waste can be used by another industry to help them decarbonise as well and just to grow their business. It's a pretty exciting time for what's happening here, but for us, most of

the jobs are in industry, and we want to see those industries grow, but we want to see them sustainable into the future and have products that they make that markets around the world want to buy.

And what a lot of people in Australia and overseas don't realise is that Gladstone is really a gateway to a huge amount of products that come into Australia. The products come on the ships, and then they're trucked out or on the trains. Yeah, obviously, yeah.

We've got a lot of special around fuel. A lot of fuel comes to our port central, and port central is a great location. It's a naturally deep port, and Gladstone has, in my opinion, the best harbour in Australia, if not one of the best in the world.

And I've seen a lot of some of the really big ones around Rotterdam and places like that, and in India as well. Our port is really unique. It's protected by the Harbour Islands, so it provides safe passage.

We also have, of course, cruise ships that we're visiting a lot more often before COVID, but they're starting to come back now, which is fantastic. We have a designated cruise terminal right down there at East Shores as well. And, yeah, there's so many products that do come in and out of our port, but we're growing that as well.

It's been the port's plan to increase bulk production, bulk exports around containerisation and things as well. Of course, we have three LNG plants on Curtis Island, which exports LNG around the world. We still export a lot of coal around the world as well, metallurgical coal and thermal coal.

So there's plenty of multi-cargo. It's a multi-cargo port, and we're just going to continue to grow that. As far as the town itself goes socially, people have plenty of options here.

There's lots of clubs and bars and restaurants to hang out at. Yeah, well, there's only really one nightclub for the young generation, but the nightlife is still very good. There's plenty of hotels and pubs that are open until beyond midnight.

But if they want to go dancing, I suppose most of that happens at the... It's called My Place. It's not My Place, but it's MIE Place Nightclub. The old nightclub when I was a kid is where Auckland House is now.

It was called Club Marina. It changed its name to Visions and Players, and then it's now part of the Waterfront Precinct. And actually, the club itself is actually the Maritime Museum.

So it's right around near Auckland House and it's turned into a Maritime Museum, which is amazing. Yes, and there's the other place, which we must mention is the Glaston Entertainment Centre, which is fantastic for shows, all that sort of thing. Yeah, well, we redeveloped our main street a number of years ago, put a number of precincts in, and Civic Square, which is right at the

front of the council chamber, so we've redeveloped that to make sure that this is where people, you know, want to come into the CBD.

It's a friendly environment. But the biggest redevelopment we did was out the front of the Entertainment Centre. So we relocated the library from near the art gallery, moved it opposite the Entertainment Centre, redeveloped an old building there, car parking underneath, and it allows for expansion for the library as well.

Condoon Street's on a hill, so we had to put some level out so that the eateries out the front there, the Thai restaurant and others, you can go sit out on the street at the front of the Grand Hotel, you can see the same, where people can sit on, you know, protected streets, seating, but flat and level rather than sort of on a hill. And then, of course, the Entertainment Centre, the Lightbox, which is just amazing, food, tea, coffee and all the rest of it, has really, in using the former mayor's a few years ago, he called it the cappuccinoization of Glaston and then the shardinization of Glaston. I won't steal his saying, that was Peter, good on your Pete.

But what has happened is, by redeveloping and renovating, I suppose, is the right word, our main street, it's certainly attracted a lot more sorts of businesses into town. And we have the next stage, which is down further, which is part of the Harbour Arbor, which when the cruise ship passengers come in, they walk along our feast on East Market, which we put on a whole big market just for cruise ship passengers, and then at the end of that, they get towards the Yacht Club, which is a heritage listed building, and they look up the main street, where we're going to have some shade there and some, I guess, spaces where they can sort of stop and have a break as well and enjoy our main street as well. We just need to get some more retail back into the main street.

It would be just lovely. How can people find out more about the Glaston area? Your slogan is, Glad to be here, which is a fantastic slogan. Yeah, or, Glad you made it.

Glad you made it is what we, glad to be here, either or. We're glad you made it is what we have been pushing. It's about attracting, for that main campaign, it's been about attracting medical professionals and other professionals to our region to say, you know, have a look at Glaston, there's so much on offer.

And when you come here and check out everything we've got from the fishing to all those tourism facilities we set and the job opportunities, you'll be glad you made it. And that's what that's all about. You can check that campaign out, it's online.

You can also check out Council's website. But I would really push people towards our glastonregion.info, which is our tourism information centre. And that has so much of all the exciting stuff that happens.

We've got some amazing events in our region, none more so than Easter in Glaston. So I've got

to mention that. That's the biggest time of the year for us.

We have our 1770 festival, our Mount Larkham show. We have the Blues and Roots Festival in Agnes Water as well. We have the old station flying in coming up.

There's so many major events, of course, the Boyntonham Hookup, but our biggest event of the year is Easter in Glaston and it's a whole bunch of events. So it centres around the Brisbane and Glaston yacht race, leaves Brisbane on Good Friday, 76 years or 77 years running now. All the yachts sail up into Glaston and to welcome them we put on a massive harbour festival, which is a family-friendly festival, live entertainment every night, the rides and sideshow early and all the rest of it.

We have a big village. We put right there on O'Connor Wharf, which welcomes them in. We have a long lunch on Good Friday.

There's a seafood festival on the sad day. There's a line crossing party to welcome all the yachts in on the Sunday. And there's so many other events as well.

This year they had a street parade with all the cars and everything that participated in the Speedway. We've got the races on, the big Easter races in Glaston, the horse racing that is. There's a raft race and there's fireworks every night.

Best time of the year. If you're ever thinking of coming to Glaston, no matter where you are in Australia, lock in Easter one year and you won't be sad. You'll be very happy you made it, or what was that? You'll be glad you did.

Councillor Matt Burnett, Mayor of the General Glanston Region. Thank you very much for being on Travel Radio Australia. It's been a pleasure.

Thank you.